

A FREE RESOURCE

THE PROPOSAL CHECKLIST

The seven sections a clear proposal needs — and the clauses that prevent most disputes.

Print it. Keep it next to your draft.

Companion to The Proposal System (\$79).

PART ONE

01

THE SEVEN-SECTION STRUCTURE

Every proposal you send should contain these seven sections, in this order. If you are tempted to skip one, that is the section that will cost you the most money.

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| ☐ Introduction | Who you are, who they are, the date, and one sentence on why you are writing. |
| ☐ Situation | The buyer's situation in their words, quoted from the discovery call. Not your interpretation. |
| ☐ Scope | The specific deliverables you will produce. Each named as a noun, not a verb. |
| ☐ Exclusions | What you will not produce. Named with the same precision as the scope. |
| ☐ Approach | How the work happens — phases, dependencies, decision points. Not a Gantt chart. |
| ☐ Price & terms | The number, the deposit, the milestones, the due dates, the late-payment consequence. |
| ☐ Decision | What you need from the buyer to start, by when, and what happens if you do not hear back. |

PART TWO · THE SCOPE-AND-EXCLUSIONS PROMPTS

Before you write the scope, answer these eight prompts in writing. Most scope disputes are not about what was in the proposal — they are about what was never named.

01 What does the buyer receive on the day we deliver? Name the file, document, or session.

02 How many rounds of revision are included? What counts as one round?

03 What is the source of the inputs we need — and what happens if they are late?

04 What is the working file format, and do we hand it over? If not, name it as an exclusion.

05 Is travel, hosting, software, or stock included? If not, name it as an exclusion.

06 Is there a third party whose cooperation we depend on? Name them and the dependency.

07 What is the support window after delivery — and what is excluded from it?

08 What would the buyer be surprised to learn is not included? Write it down now.

PART THREE

02

THE REVISION-BOUNDARY FRAMEWORK

Pick one tier per project and write it into the proposal. The tier is not a discount — it is a stated agreement about what a revision is. Silence on this point is the single most common source of scope creep.

LIGHT**1 round**

Consolidated written feedback from one stakeholder, applied in one pass. New direction after the round is a new phase, billed separately.

STANDARD**2 rounds**

Consolidated written feedback from the agreed decision-maker, applied in two passes. Changes to the brief, the audience, or the deliverable format after round one restart the scope.

GENEROUS**3 rounds**

Consolidated written feedback from up to three stakeholders, applied in three passes. Verbal feedback does not count. New deliverables requested after round two are billed as a change order.

PART FOUR · PAYMENT-TERMS CHECKLIST

- ☐ A deposit is required to start — typically 30–50% of the total. Name the amount.
- ☐ Milestone payments are tied to deliverables, not to calendar dates.
- ☐ Final payment is due on delivery — not on the buyer's internal approval.
- ☐ Late-payment interest or fee is stated, with the trigger date named.
- ☐ The proposal names the currency, the method, and the invoicing window.
- ☐ The deposit is non-refundable once work has begun — stated in writing.

PART FIVE · PRE-SEND REVIEW

- ☐ The buyer's name and company are spelled correctly.
- ☐ The scope and exclusions are in matching grammatical form.
- ☐ Every number in the proposal appears in two places (price, terms, and schedule agree).
- ☐ The deposit amount and due date are stated in the same sentence.
- ☐ The revision tier is named — not implied.
- ☐ The decision deadline is named — not "let me know."
- ☐ There are no optional add-ons the buyer did not ask about.
- ☐ There is no phrase you would be embarrassed to read aloud to the buyer.

- ☐ You have removed every adjective that does not earn its place.
- ☐ You have read it once out loud, start to finish, without skipping.

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